Ms Suu Kyi does not seem like a bad person to those who have met her and who know her personally. And it would be too facile to reduce her response to the Rohingya crisis to mere craven politicking. So how can a reasonably decent person who has a life-long history of self-sacrifice in the service of the rights of others look on the plight of the Rohingyas with such sang-froid? Why is it that an entire country that has suffered decades of oppression under military rule alongside the Rohingyas remains so unmoved by their suffering now, or in many cases are even supportive of the actions against them?

As far as we can tell Aung San Suu Kyi and most of her countrymen have certain anti-Muslim views and attitudes that inure them against empathising with the suffering of their neighbours. Her writings, which I discuss at length in the main text, show that she subscribes to the common Theravada Buddhist position that the state must protect the state religion and that religious diversity is a threat to the Buddhist sasana. Muslims cannot properly be part of the body politic in Ms Suu Kyi's ideal vision for Myanmar. The majority of her countrymen share that opinion.

Both Ms Suu Kyi and her fellow Burmese seem to have a deep and visceral aversion to Muslim individuals in person too. She recently complained publicly about the BBC after an interview because she had not been given prior notice that her interviewer would be Muslim. The Muslim in question, the BBC's Mishal Hussain, is one of the corporation's most respected journalists and had no political axe to grind with Ms Suu Kyi. Her 'offence' was to ask about Ms Suu Kyi about her response to the humanitarian problems that were already widely reported by the Western press.

Aung San Suu Kyi's stance on the issue of the Rohingyas is emblematic of the situation in the country, not because she leads the pack on discriminatory views, but rather because she echoes perfectly the attitudes of an entire society. Her voice, when she issues measured defences of the military operations in Rakhine state, or her deafening silence when prompted to consider the situation from the position of the Rohingya victims, mirrors that exactly of 90 per cent of her country's population.

And that is precisely why the genocide in Rakhine state is happening, and why it will not stop until all the Rohingyas are pushed over the border to Bangladesh, while stragglers will continue to be hunted down by the military. Nobody likes violence. Some, the nationalist extremists, condone